

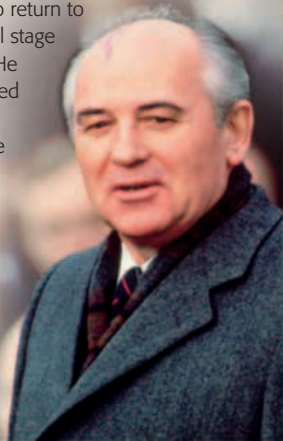
Down with Lenin

Gorbachev's decision to allow criticism of the communist system resulted in demands for an end to repressive one-party government. Protesters called for multi-party elections and democracy.

RUSSIAN PRESIDENT (1931–)

MIKHAIL GORBACHEV

Mikhail Gorbachev was born in Stavropol in southwestern Russia. He became active in politics at an early age and became leader of the Soviet Union in 1985. Gorbachev transformed Soviet relations with the Western world, and is widely credited with reversing the arms race and ending the Cold War (see pp.406–07). He attempted to solve Soviet economic and political problems through programs of domestic reform. After the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991, he made several failed attempts to return to the political stage in Russia. He was awarded the Nobel Peace Prize in 1990.



“Upon the success of *perestroika* depends the future of peace.”

MIKHAIL GORBACHEV, 1987

openly contested elections for some members of the Congress of People's Deputies (Soviet Parliament). However, he soon faced demands for greater concessions from a newly elected people's deputy, Boris Yeltsin.

Gorbachev and Yeltsin

Yeltsin had become popular in the Soviet Union because of his open criticism of Gorbachev and *perestroika*. In 1990, he was elected President of the Russian Federation, the largest Soviet republic. He used this position to attack Gorbachev and the CPSU, insisting that the party should no longer dominate government. His resignation from the party in July 1990 was a public challenge. Next to Yeltsin, Gorbachev looked suddenly weak and old-fashioned.

Throughout 1990, Gorbachev struggled to hold the Soviet Union together, sending troops into

Azerbaijan to suppress inter-ethnic fighting, and opposing independence in the Baltic States. On August 19, 1991, a committee of CPSU hardliners staged a coup, arresting Gorbachev and his advisors. They declared a state of emergency and announced their intention to reestablish old-style Soviet rule. Yeltsin rushed to the White House (the Russian Parliament building), and called on the people to come and protect their parliament. Support for Yeltsin ended the coup. Gorbachev was reinstated as president after four days, but Yeltsin was the true hero of the hour and Gorbachev's prestige was irreversibly damaged.

In September 1991, the Congress of People's Deputies granted independence to all Soviet republics, dissolving the USSR. With no union to rule over, Gorbachev had effectively been downsized. He resigned his post in December 1991.

The collapse of communism in Russia created economic instability and demands for independence in Chechnya.

YELTSIN IN POWER

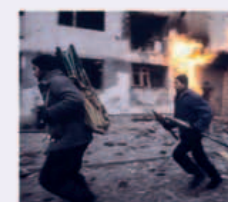
Following the collapse of communism, Boris Yeltsin introduced a **market economy** in the Russian Federation. **Inflation soared** and domestic production plummeted. Russia was plunged into **recession** with greater material hardships than had been suffered under communism or *perestroika*. In 1993 the Congress of People's Deputies attempted to impeach Yeltsin, but he survived in office, eventually resigning in 1999, a **deeply unpopular figure**.



BORIS YELTSIN

WAR IN CHECHNYA

After 1991, the Russian Federation faced **independence** demands from its southern province of Chechnya. In 1994, Yeltsin sent troops into Grozny, the Chechen capital, to crush the rebels. The war lasted until 1996 with **serious casualties** on both sides. After Russian withdrawal, the unrest continued and a second war began in 1999.



FIGHTING IN CHECHNYA

The former USSR in 1991

After the USSR's collapse, the vast nation split into 15 separate states, the largest of which was the Russian Federation. These established independent governments and many began economic cooperation as members of the Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS).

KEY

- Territory controlled by USSR from 1945
- Russian Federation from 1991
- Commonwealth of Independent States, 1991

